

IMPERIAL OPULENCE

France during Napoleon III's Second Empire (1852–1870) was a place of prosperity, quickly made fortunes, and rampant consumerism. Visitors flocked to see Baron Haussmann's transformation of Paris into a city of grand boulevards, and the theatres, opera houses, and new department stores buzzed with life. The favourite court painter, Franz Xaver Winterhalter, who painted the scene opposite, captured a glittering imperial life, providing powerful public relations for the regime.

At the centre of this court life was Napoleon's striking, Spanish-born empress, Eugénie – a leading fashion icon of her day, whose patronage of designer Charles Frederick Worth made him the first real "dictator" of Paris fashion. Eugénie (fourth from the left) wears trimmings in purple, a colour she loved. Purple was an expensive natural dye, suitable for royalty, when this was painted in 1855, but just one year later a synthetic dye was made and soon "mauve madness" swept Europe and the United States, fuelled by Eugénie's example. The luxuriantly stylish court ladies, shown in tulle, taffeta, silk, muslin, lace, and ribbons, also display the newly fashionable crinolines, which became enormous during the Second Empire. In 1861 one English fashion magazine noted: "The Empress Eugénie[s] petticoats... stood out a great deal: and following her example, all the Paris Ladies are wearing their skirts very wide and ample."

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Would you believe that, in the latter half of the nineteenth century, there are bearded milliners...who...take the exact dimensions of the highest titled women in Paris – robe them, unrobe them, and make them turn backward and forward before them?

CHARLES DICKENS, *ALL THE YEAR ROUND*, 1863

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◀ THE EMPRESS EUGENIE SURROUNDED BY HER LADIES IN WAITING

Winterhalter's painting is in the *fête gallante* style (beautiful people shown in pastoral settings) of 18th-century artist J-A Watteau. Eugénie was fascinated by this period, especially by Marie Antoinette, and some of her outfits incorporated 18th-century features.

